NurseSalaryIntel.com

Nurse Contract Audit Kit

Know What You're Signing Before You Sign It

10 Critical Audit Checks

Red Flag Warnings

Negotiation Scripts BONUS

10	10	5
Audit Checkpoints	Red Flags Explained	Negotiation Scripts

Built for travel nurses, per diem nurses, and staff nurses reviewing any contract.
nursesalaryintel.com

Before You Sign Anything — Read This.

The average travel nurse contract contains 8-10 clauses that can cost you thousands if you don't know what to look for. Most nurses sign within 24–48 hours under pressure from recruiters. This kit gives you the knowledge and the words to push back — confidently.

Three Steps to Using This Kit

01

AUDIT

Work through each of the 10 checkpoints. Fill in the blanks as you review your actual contract. Flag anything that doesn't match what you were told verbally.

02

SCORE RED FLAGS

Each section lists specific red flags. If you check any of them, that section needs attention before you sign.

03

NEGOTIATE

Use the Bonus Negotiation Scripts (page 11) to respond to your recruiter or HR contact. Word-for-word templates — just fill in your numbers.

What's Included in This Kit

- **10 Audit Checkpoints** — Every critical section of a nursing contract, with fill-in fields to record your actual terms.
- **Red Flag Warnings** — Specific contract language and terms that should trigger a conversation before you sign.
- **Negotiation Tips** — For each checkpoint, a targeted tip on how to push back or ask for better terms.
- **BONUS: NegotiationScripts** — Five word-for-word email/call scripts — for salary, housing, cancellation, completion bonus, etc.
- **Offer Scorecard** — Score your entire offer on 8 dimensions to make a clear accept/negotiate/decline decision.

Contract Audit — Items 1 & 2

1 Payment Terms & Schedule

Verify exact payrate, frequency (weekly/bi-weekly), and any deductions.

VERIFY IN YOUR CONTRACT

Hourly/weekly rate offered: $

Pay frequency (circle): Weekly / Bi-weekly / Monthly

Deductions listed in contract:

Taxable wage vs. stipend breakdown: $

RED FLAGS

- Pay rate stated verbally but NOT in writing — get it in the contract.
- Deductions for housing/fees that weren't mentioned during recruitment.
- "Blended rate" language without a clear taxable vs. non-taxable breakdown.
- No penalty clause if the facility delays payment.

NEGOTIATION TIP: Ask for the blended rate AND the taxable hourly rate in writing. A $2,400/week package looks different once you see the $18/hr taxable base.

2 Contract Cancellation Terms

Understand termination conditions for both you and the facility.

VERIFY IN YOUR CONTRACT

Notice required by facility to cancel: _____ days

Notice required by you to cancel: _____ days

Cancellation penalty (if any): $

Payout for early cancellation by facility: $

RED FLAGS

- Facility can cancel with 0–7 days notice but you need 30+ days — one-sided.
- No clause requiring the facility to pay any compensation if they cancel early.
- "At-will" termination language with zero notice protection for you.
- Bonus or stipend clawback triggered by facility-initiated cancellation.

NEGOTIATION TIP: Negotiate equal notice periods. If they cancel, you should receive at least 2–4 weeks of pay. Push for a guaranteed-hours clause if possible.

3 Housing & Lodging Benefits

Confirm stipend amount, tax treatment, and what happens if housing falls through.

VERIFY IN YOUR CONTRACT

Housing stipend (weekly): $

Is stipend tax-free? (IRS compliance): Yes / No / Unclear

Facility-provided housing? Yes / No

If facility housing falls through, backup plan:

RED FLAGS

- Stipend below GSA per diem rates for the assignment city (check gsa.gov).
- Tax-free stipend with no proof of maintaining a tax home — IRS audit risk.
- No written plan if facility-provided housing is unavailable at start date.
- Stipend paid out mid-contract rather than weekly with your paycheck.

NEGOTIATION TIP: Look up the GSA lodging rate for your assignment city. Your housing stipend should be at or near that rate. If it's below, or significantly negotiate ask for a higher taxable hourly rate to compensate.

4 Health Insurance Coverage

Review plan details, coverage start date, and your out-of-pocket premium costs.

VERIFY IN YOUR CONTRACT

Plan type (HMO / PPO / HDHP):

Weekly premium deducted from paycheck: $

Coverage start date:

Coverage gap during contract transition? Yes / No

RED FLAGS

- Coverage doesn't start until 30–60 days into the contract — major gap.
- Premium cost deducted from the stipend, not stated upfront.
- No coverage during the gap between two back-to-back contracts.
- Plan is unavailable in your assignment state (HMO network issues).

NEGOTIATION TIP: If day-one coverage isn't offered, ask to negotiate an additional weekly stipend to cover short-term marketplace insurance during the gap period.

Contract Audit — Items 5 & 6

5 Licensure & Certification Costs

Verify reimbursement for state licenses, certifications, and renewals.

VERIFY IN YOUR CONTRACT

State license reimbursed? Yes / No / Partial — Amount: $

Certifications covered (list):

Reimbursement timing: Upfront / After start / After completion

Repayment required if you leave early? Yes / No — Terms:

RED FLAGS

- Licensure reimbursement only paid after contract completion — you pay upfront.
- Reimbursement clawed back if you don't complete the contract, even if the facility cancels.
- Specialty certifications (ACLS, BLS, PALS) not covered despite being required.
- No mention of license reimbursement at all — ask before assuming.

NEGOTIATION TIP: Licensure costs can run $200–$600 per state. If the agency won't cover it upfront, ask for a sign-on advance or structured reimbursement within 30 days of start.

6 Completion Bonus

Confirm bonus amount, payment timeline, and conditions required to receive it.

VERIFY IN YOUR CONTRACT

Completion bonus amount: $

Paid: At completion / With final paycheck / Within ___ days

Conditions to qualify (list any):

What voids the bonus?

RED FLAGS

- Bonus contingent on a rating or evaluation by the facility — subjective criteria.
- "Satisfactory performance" required but not defined anywhere in the contract.
- Bonus paid 60–90 days after completion, not at contract end.
- No completion bonus offered at all — negotiate one; most agencies have flexibility.

NEGOTIATION TIP: Always ask if a completion bonus is available even if it's not listed. A common range is $500–$2,500. Ensure the payment trigger is defined as the last day of the contract, not facility approval.

Contract Audit — Items 7 & 8

7 Shift Differential Pay

Check night, weekend, and holiday pay premium rates.

VERIFY IN YOUR CONTRACT

Night shift differential: $___/hr or ___% over base

Weekend differential: $___/hr or ___% over base

Holiday differential: $___/hr or ___% over base

Overtime rate (after 40 hrs): $___/hr or ___x base

RED FLAGS

- Differentials promised verbally but excluded from the written contract.
- Differentials significantly below facility employee rates (ask other nurses).
- "Float pool" differential lower than your specialty unit differential.
- Holiday pay classified as "straight time" rather than time-and-a-half.

NEGOTIATION TIP: Night and weekend differentials should be at minimum $3–$8/hr above base. If an assignment requires weekends or this is nights, non-negotiable. Get exact dollar amounts, not vague percentages.

8 On-Call Requirements

Understand on-call frequency, compensation, and expected response time.

VERIFY IN YOUR CONTRACT

On-call shifts per week/month required:

On-call compensation rate: $___/hr

Call-back pay rate: $___/hr (if called in)

Required response time: _____ minutes

RED FLAGS

- On-call required but compensated at $0 or below minimum wage.
- On-call not mentioned during recruitment but written into the contract.
- Response time of 30 minutes or less — effectively restricts your off time.
- On-call shifts counted in your required weekly hours, reducing regular pay.

NEGOTIATION TIP: On-call pay should be at minimum $3–5/hr while on standby. If called in, that time should switch to your full hourly rate any (including applicable differential). Clarify this in writing.

Contract Audit — Items 9 & 10

9 Travel & Relocation Costs

Verify reimbursement for travel to the assignment and return home.

VERIFY IN YOUR CONTRACT

Travel stipend (to assignment): $

Return travel covered? Yes / No — Amount: $

Mileage or airfare reimbursement method:

Reimbursement timing: Before start / First paycheck / Contract end

RED FLAGS

- No travel reimbursement for assignments more than 4 hours from your home.
- One-way travel only — no coverage for the return trip.
- Reimbursement only if you complete the full contract (facility cancellations excluded).
- Mileage reimbursed at below IRS standard rate (currently $0.67/mile for 2024).

NEGOTIATION TIP: For assignments over 500 miles, ask for airfare or a flat travel allowance of $300–$600 each way. If driving, push for IRS in standard mileage rate. Get this the contract — not just a recruiter promise.

10 Floating Policy

Understand when and where you can be floated to other units.

VERIFY IN YOUR CONTRACT

Float units listed in contract:

Float frequency allowed per shift or week:

Additional pay when floated? Yes / No — Amount: $

Can you refuse an unsafe float assignment? Yes / No

RED FLAGS

- "Float as needed" with no restriction on which units or how often.
- No additional compensation when floated to a higher-acuity unit.
- No right to refuse float to a unit outside your competency.
- Float clause broader than what you were told during the offer call.

NEGOTIATION TIP: Limit your float clause to units within your specialty and competency. If you're an ICU nurse, you should not be floated to a med-surg without additional compensation. Push for unit-specific float restriction in writing.

BONUS: Negotiation Scripts

These scripts are designed to be professional, specific, and non-confrontational — they work.

Script 01

Requesting a Higher Base Pay Rate

"Hi[Recruiter Name], thank you for sending the contract. I've reviewed it carefully and I'd like to discuss the base rate. Based on NurseSalaryIntel.com data for [specialty] in [city], the market rate is currently $[X]–$[Y]/hr for my experience level. The current offer is $[Z]/hr. Is there flexibility to bring the taxable base rate to $[your target]? I'm committed to making this assignment work — I just want to make sure the compensation reflects the market. Can we set up a quick call today or tomorrow?"

Script 02

PushingBack on a One-Sided Cancellation Clause

"Hi [Recruiter Name], I noticed the cancellation clause allows the facility to cancel with [X] days notice while requiring [Y] days notice from me. I'd like to request equal notice periods, and a clause that guarantees [2–4 weeks] of pay if the facility cancels after I've started. This is fairly standard for travel contracts and protects both sides. Can you check with the team on this revision before I sign?"

Script 03

Askingfor a Completion Bonus

"Hi[Recruiter Name], before I finalize thecontract I wanted to ask — is a completion bonus available for this assignment? I've successfully completed [X] travel contracts without cancellation and I take completion very seriously. Even a $[500–1,500] bonus paid on the last day of the contract would mean a lot and confirms both sides are committed. If that's not available, is there flexibility on the weekly rate to reflect the same value? Happy to discuss."

Script 04

Clarifying Float Policy Restrictions

"Hi[RecruiterName], can we add a float restriction to the contract? As an [ICU/specialty] nurse, I'm comfortable floating within [specific units], but I'd need additional orientation and compensation for units outside my competency. I'd like the contract to specify that I can only be floated to [list acceptable units] and that float pay is at least $[X] above my base rate. This protects patient safety and my license. Can we add that language?"

Script 05

Negotiating Licensure Reimbursement Timing

"Hi [Recruiter Name], the contract shows licensure reimbursement paid at contract completion. My [state] license application costs $[amount] and I need to pay upfront before I can start. Can we structure this as an advance on day one, or reimbursement within the first two paychecks? I'm happy to sign an acknowledgement that it will be repaid if I don't complete the contract. I just can't float the cost for 13 weeks. Is that workable?"

Phone Negotiation Scripts

PROTIP: Always open with "I'm really excited about this assignment" before any ask. It disarms defensive reactions.
Use these scripts verbatim or adapt the bracketed sections to your situation. Read them aloud first so they feel natural.

Opening the Negotiation Call

CONTEXT: Use this when your recruiter calls to "confirm" the contract. This is your window.

YOU: Hi [Name], I'm really excited about the [facility] assignment. I've gone through the contract and I have a couple of things I'd like to go over before I sign. Do you have 10 minutes now, or is there a better time today?

THEM: [They agree to talk or schedule a time]

YOU: Great. I want to make this work — I just want to make sure we're aligned on a few specifics. The first thing I noticed is [specific issue]. Can we address that?

Asking for a Pay Increase by Phone

CONTEXT: Use when your base taxable rate is below market.

YOU: I pulled the NurseSalaryIntel data for [specialty] in [city] — the average taxable hourly rate for my experience level is $[X]. The contract shows $[Y]. Is there room to move the base rate? Even $2–3/hr makes a real difference over 13 weeks.

THEM: [Likely says they'll check with the agency/facility]

YOU: I appreciate that. I'm not trying to be difficult — I just want to go in knowing the rate is fair. What's the ceiling you can get approved? I can work with a number if we're in the right range.

Pushing Back on a One-Sided Clause

CONTEXT: Use when the cancellation, float, or on-call clause is unfair.

YOU: I noticed [specific clause — e.g., the float policy says I can be floated anywhere]. That's a little open-ended for me. Can we tighten the language to [specific units / specific limits]? I'm not trying to be difficult — I just want to know what I'm agreeing to.

THEM: [They may say 'that's standard' or 'I'll have to check']

YOU: I understand it may be standard, but standard doesn't always mean it's fair. I'd feel much more comfortable with a specific unit list. Is that something you can put in a contract addendum? Even one sentence would work.

Legal Addendum Language

IMPORTANT: These are suggested addendum clauses. Send via email as an attachment or paste inline. Always request confirmation in writing.

Equal Cancellation Protection Clause

RISKADDRESSED: Protects you if the facility cancels your contract early.

SUGGESTED ADDENDUM LANGUAGE:
Addendum to Section [X] - Cancellation: In the event that the Facility or Agency initiates cancellation of this agreement after the contract start date, Nurse shall be entitled to receive [14] calendar days of compensation at the agreed weekly rate, or payment through the remaining contract term, whichever is lesser. Facility-initiated cancellations shall not trigger any clawback of housing stipends, completion bonuses, or licensure reimbursements already disbursed.

Float Restriction Clause

RISKADDRESSED: Limits floating to units within your competency and specialty.

SUGGESTED ADDENDUM LANGUAGE:
Addendum to Section [X] - Float Policy: Nurse may only be floated to the following units: [List: e.g., MICU, SICU, Step-Down]. Floating to units outside this list requires written consent from Nurse and shall be compensated at a rate no less than $[X]/hr above the base hourly rate. Nurse retains the right to decline float assignments to units for which they have not received facility-specific orientation.

Guaranteed Weekly Hours Clause

RISKADDRESSED: Ensures you are paid even if the facility cancels your shifts.

SUGGESTED ADDENDUM LANGUAGE:
Addendum to Section [X] - Guaranteed Hours: Agency guarantees Nurse a minimum of [36] hours of compensated time per week during the contract term. In weeks where the Facility cancels Nurse's scheduled shifts and total hours fall below [36], Nurse shall receive guaranteed pay for the difference at the base hourly rate. This guarantee does not apply to absences initiated by Nurse.

Completion Bonus Trigger Clause

RISKADDRESSED: Removes subjective performance conditions from your bonus.

SUGGESTED ADDENDUM LANGUAGE:
Addendum to Section [X] - Completion Bonus: A completion bonus of $[Amount] shall be paid to Nurse within [7] business days of the final contracted shift date, provided Nurse has worked all scheduled shifts during the contract term and has not voluntarily terminated prior to the end date. Facility performance evaluations shall not be a condition of completion bonus eligibility.

Licensure Reimbursement Advance Clause

RISKADDRESSED: Gets your licensure costs covered up front, not at the end.

SUGGESTED ADDENDUM LANGUAGE:
Addendum to Section [X] - Licensure Reimbursement: Agency agrees to reimburse Nurse for state licensure application and processing fees up to $[Amount] within [14] days of contract execution or prior to the assignment start date, whichever is earlier. If Nurse voluntarily terminates the contract before [50%] completion, Nurse agrees to repay a pro-rated portion of this reimbursement.

When They Push Back

Pushback is normal.Itdoesn'tmeanno--itmeanstheyhaven'theardagood enough reason yet.

Use these exact responses. Read them aloud first so they feel natural.

THEY SAY: **"That's our standard contract. Everyone signs it."**

EMAIL/TEXT: "I understand it's standard -- I just want to make sure it works for both sides. Can we add one sentence to address [specific issue]? It doesn't change the rest of the contract."

PHONE: "I'm not asking for a full rewrite -- just one clause. Most agencies I've worked with have been able to make this small change. Is there someone I can speak with about it?"

THEY SAY: **"We can't change the pay rate -- it's set by the facility."**

EMAIL/TEXT: "If the base rate is fixed, can we look at other options -- a higher completion bonus, an additional travel stipend, or a sign-on advance? I want to make the total package work."

PHONE: "If the hourly rate is a ceiling, what flexibility does the agency have? I'm looking at the total package -- housing, bonus, differentials. Where can we add value?"

THEY SAY: **"If you don't sign today, we may lose the slot."**

EMAIL/TEXT: "I understand there's urgency and I want this assignment. I just need 24 hours to review two clauses. I've signed [X] contracts without cancellation. I'm a safe bet. Can we have until tomorrow morning?"

PHONE: "A nurse who signs under pressure and then cancels is worse for everyone. Give me until tomorrow and I will have a decision."

THEY SAY: **"The float policy is required by the facility -- we can't remove it."**

EMAIL/TEXT: "I'm not asking to remove it -- I'm asking to define it. Can we add language limiting floats to [specific units]? It protects the facility too since they nurse who's competent on those units."

PHONE: "My concern is patient safety and my license. Can we at least define which units are acceptable? It's a safety issue as much as a contract one."

THEY SAY: **"We've never offered a completion bonus for this assignment."**

EMAIL/TEXT: "I've completed [X] contracts without cancellation. A $500-$1,000 bonus on a 13-week assignment is a small cost for the certainty of a reliable nurse. Is there any flexibility on the agency side?"

PHONE: "Even if it's not standard, it's worth asking. A completion incentive reduces cancellations for everyone. I'm an easy yes if we can add it."

Offer Scorecard

Rate each dimension 1-5. Total score guides your decision.

40-50 Strong offer -- Accept with confidence | 28-39 Acceptable -- Negotiate 1-2 key items | 15-27 Red flags - Need to Negiotate

Category	What You're Evaluating	Score (1-5)
Base Pay & Rate Structure	Is it at or above market for specialty + location?	
Housing / Stipend Package	Does the stipend cover actual housing costs in the city?	
Health Insurance	Does coverage start day one? Is the premium reasonable?	
Cancellation Protections	Are notice periods equal? Protected if facility cancels?	
Completion Bonus	Is there a bonus? Clearly defined with a fair trigger?	
Shift Differentials & OT	Are night/weekend/holiday rates competitive?	
Float & Schedule Policy	Is float limited to your competency and specialty?	
Travel & Relocation	Is round-trip travel covered at a reasonable rate?	
Licensure & Certification	Are required licenses and certifications covered?	
On-Call Fairness	Is on-call clearly defined and fairly compensated?	

TOTAL SCORE: _____ / 50 **DECISION:** [ ] Accept [ ] Negotiate [ ] Decline

Key Action Items Before Signing:

NurseSalaryIntel.com

You Deserve to Be Paid What You're Worth.

For real hospital-level salary data, specialty comparisons, and automated contract intelligence, visit:

nursesalaryintel.com

- **Salary Database**
  Compareyourofferagainst real RN wages by hospital and city
- **Contract Risk Scanner**
  Runyourfullcontractthrough our automated audit tool
- **Negotiation Library**
  Scripts,tactics,andrealcase studies from nurses who pushed back

This document is for informational purposes only and does not constitute legal or financial advice.
Always consult with a licensed professional for contract-specific guidance.

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